

MANISH RAJPUT

**THE TAKEDOWN** Wrestlers Bajrang Punia, Vinesh Phogat and Sakshi Malik during the protest against federation chief Brij Bhushan Singh (left) at Jantar Mantar, Apr. 28

to stand in solidarity with the wrestlers, who are led by Commonwealth and Asian Games gold medallist Vinesh Phogat and Olympics bronze medallists Sakshi Malik and Bajrang Punia.

It was tough to stand up against powerful people, says Vinesh, and "appealing to the public was the only avenue left" after no action was taken despite repeated appeals to the authorities. In fact, the wrestlers had first launched a sit-in at Jantar Mantar on January 18, but it was called off soon after a meeting with Union sports minister Anurag Thakur, who ordered the constitution of an oversight committee to probe the allegations. Even though the panel submitted its report in the first week of April, its contents were not made public. Amid reports that it gave Brij Bhushan a clean chit and the WFI announcing its election for May 7 (later declared "null and void" by the sports ministry), the wrestlers decided to return to the protest site.

Brij Bhushan, who has remained ensconced on the WFI president's chair for three terms now, had said that he won't be contesting the election again. Talking to mediapersons at his residence in Gonda on April 30, he refused to resign from the post though. "Resigning as the president of the Wrestling Federation of India is not a big deal for me," he said, "but I will not do it as a criminal." Terming the protest a conspiracy hatched by a Congress leader and a top wrestler, Brij Bhushan claimed he has an audio clip to prove his allegation and will hand it over to the Delhi Police "when the time comes". "I am ready to face any kind of investigation... I am completely innocent and have full faith in the Supreme Court and Delhi Police," added the BJP leader.

But for Brij Bhushan, this is not the first brush with controversies. From being named as an accused in the 1992 Babri Masjid demolition case to spending time in the Tihar jail in the mid-'90s for allegedly harbouring gangster Dawood Ibrahim's men involved in a shootout, the *bahubali* politician holds sway in the Awadh region of northeastern UP and has the capacity to influence results in six to eight Lok Sabha seats. Though he got a clean chit in both cases, Brij Bhushan still has four cases pending against him, including on the charges of attempt to murder and robbery, his election affidavit reveals. Add to that a murder to avenge an associate's killing, to which he unabashedly confessed in a video interview with *The Lallantop* last year. Besides this alleged nexus of crime and politics, Brij Bhushan wields enormous clout via a chain of nearly 50 educational institutes spread across a 100-km belt from Ayodhya to Shravasti. Sources in the BJP say his poll machinery is run almost entirely by this set-up, with his family members playing a key role in both his businesses and political activities, independent of the party.

**Protesting wrestlers say they won't leave Jantar Mantar till the six-time MP and WFI chief Brij Bhushan is arrested for alleged sexual harassment of women grapplers**

A law graduate, Brij Bhushan entered student politics in 1985. Considered close to the late Vishva Hindu Parishad chief Ashok Singhal, he went on to join the BJP and came into the limelight during the Ram temple movement. Riding on that wave, he won his first Lok Sabha election from Gonda constituency in 1991. In 2009, sensing the dwindling fortunes of the BJP, he switched to the Samajwadi Party (SP) and won from Kaiserganj. It was SP founder Mulayam Singh Yadav, say sources close to Brij Bhushan, who played an important role in getting him elected as the WFI president in 2011. Even as he returned to the BJP in 2014, Brij Bhushan, sources say, continues to share a "good bond" with the Yadav family and could even go back to the SP if denied the BJP ticket in the 2024 general election.

While Brij Bhushan is trying to preserve his political capital, those camping at Jantar Mantar are not just dealing with an onslaught of TV crews, bad weather and alleged threats of being sidelined in their careers, they are also struggling to maintain their workout routine. A woman wrestler, who does not wish to be named, says, "Many young wrestlers have abandoned the protest as they are afraid. We cannot afford to miss out on our workout for more than a week. Our whole career depends on it." Those who have stayed on wake up early in the morning and exercise for a few hours before the daily grind begins—giving media interviews, speaking to the public and handling a backlash from friends and family. "We thought people who are close to us would stay by our side, but they are the first to have turned against us," says the wrestler cited above.

So when, on April 27, Indian Olympic Association (IOA) president P.T. Usha was quoted as having suggested that the protesting wrestlers should have shown "some discipline", they were left disappointed. But amid an outpouring in the protesters' favour, both on the ground and online, Usha landed at Jantar Mantar on May 3, reportedly telling the wrestlers that she had been "misinterpreted". Brij Bhushan, too, is banking on the support of his fraternity to tide him over this latest row. The BJP leader categorically praised SP president and former UP chief minister Akhilesh Yadav, who has so far maintained silence on the matter, for "standing with the truth". Meanwhile, politicians reaching Jantar Mantar have been raising questions on the delay in Brij Bhushan's arrest despite the FIRs, including one under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences Act. With both sides not ready to relent, it looks like a fight to the finish. ■

***(With inputs from Sonali Acharjee)***